CHAPTER 5

THROUGH THE EYES OF TRAVELLERS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master medieval India through foreign travel narratives: Al-Biruni's Kitab-al-Hind (scientific inquiry and caste barriers), Ibn Battuta's Rihla (communication and dynamic cities), and Francois Bernier (Mughal property critique).

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Three Master Travellers Framework:** Al-Biruni (11th century Uzbekistan - Sanskrit textual study); Ibn Battuta (14th century Morocco - global wanderer and Delhi Qazi); Francois Bernier (17th century France - European physician at Mughal court).

• **Al-Biruni and the Sanskrit Barrier:** Authored Kitab-al-Hind (80 chapters on astronomy, philosophy, social customs); identified three barriers to understanding: Sanskrit linguistic complexity, religious exclusivity, and insular pride.

• **Ibn Battuta: Rihla and Indian Dynamism:** Travelled over 73,000 miles; praised Delhi as magnificent; marveled at postal network (horse post Uluq and foot post Dawa) and vibrant urban manufacturing bazaars.

• **Bernier's Critique of Private Property:** Physician to Dara Shukoh; authored 'Travels in the Mogul Empire'; asserted lack of private land ownership made Mughal emperor sole proprietor, degrading agriculture relative to Europe.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Al-Biruni's Epistemic Barriers} \rightarrow \{\text{Sanskrit Complexity, Religious Insularity, Self-Absorption}\}$$
Methodological Roadblocks to Cross-Cultural Understanding

$$\text{Ibn Battuta Postal Topology} \iff \text{Uluq (Horse Post every 4 miles)} \longleftrightarrow \text{Dawa (Foot Post every 1/3 mile)}$$
Sultanate Rapid Information and Intelligence Relay

$$\text{Bernier's Binary Theory} \iff \text{Crown Land Monopoly} \rightarrow \text{Despotism} + \text{Impoverished Peasantry}$$
Eurocentric Ideological Model of Asian Societies

$$\text{Travellers Tripartite Arc} \iff \text{Al-Biruni (11th c.)} \rightarrow \text{Ibn Battuta (14th c.)} \rightarrow \text{Bernier (17th c.)}$$
Seven Centuries of Foreign Perceptions of Indian Society

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Bernier's claim that the Mughal emperor owned all land was an exaggeration; peasants held customary hereditary occupancy rights, paying land revenue (tax) rather than rent.

• **Alert:** In the Sultanate postal system, the horse post was called 'Uluq' (run by royal horses stationed at distance of four miles); the foot post was called 'Dawa' (stationed every third of a mile).

• **Alert:** Al-Biruni compared the Indian caste system with ancient Persia, noting that social divisions based on occupation existed in many ancient civilizations.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. What were the three main barriers identified by Al-Biruni in understanding Indian culture and society? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Linguistic Barrier:** The Sanskrit language was vastly different from Arabic and Persian, with complex grammatical structures and subtle philosophical terms. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Religious and Cultural Exclusivity:** Differences in religious beliefs and social practices made the local populace insular and suspicious of foreigners. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Intellectual Pride and Self-Absorption:** The local intellectual elite believed their country, religion, and sciences were superior to all others, making cross-cultural sharing difficult. **[1 Mark]**

2. Describe the postal system in India as observed and recorded by Ibn Battuta in the fourteenth century. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Dual Postal Structure:** The Sultanate postal network was divided into two synchronized systems: the horse post (Uluq) and the foot post (Dawa). **[1 Mark]**

• **Horse Post (Uluq):** Stationed every four miles using royal horses to carry heavy state dispatches across major imperial highways. **[1 Mark]**

• **Foot Post (Dawa):** Stationed every one-third of a mile; swift runners carried copper-belled batons, running at top speed to deliver news and perishable fruits from Sind to Delhi in five days. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Administrative Utility:** Allowed the Sultan (Muhammad bin Tughlaq) to receive daily intelligence reports and maintain swift military control over distant provinces. **[0.5 Mark]**

3. Examine Francois Bernier's views on the absence of private property in land in Mughal India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Emperor as Sole Landlord:** Bernier believed that the Mughal emperor owned all agricultural land and distributed it among nobles who held it purely at royal pleasure. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Disastrous Agrarian Consequences:** Argued that because landholders could not pass property to their children, they made no capital investments in irrigation or soil improvement. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **European Contrast:** Projected a sharp binary contrasting prosperous European private property owners against an impoverished Indian peasantry governed by an oriental despot. **[1 Mark]**

4. What were Ibn Battuta's impressions of Indian cities and markets? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Densely Populated and Prosperous:** Described cities as bustling with trade opportunities; praised Delhi as the largest and most magnificent metropolis in the East. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Vibrant Bazaars:** Markets were not just economic centers of exchange but civic hubs housing mosques, temples, and open public spaces for music and dance performances. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. Write a short note on Al-Biruni's masterwork 'Kitab-al-Hind'. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Content and Language:** Written in lucid Arabic, divided into 80 chapters covering religion, philosophy, festivals, astronomy, alchemy, manners, metrology, and iconography. **[1 Mark]**

• **Geometric Structure:** Adopted a distinctive methodology: beginning each chapter with a question, followed by a detailed description based on Sanskrit texts, and concluding with a cross-cultural comparison. **[1 Mark]**

6. Who was Francois Bernier? Mention his official affiliation in India. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Profile:** A French physician, political philosopher, and historian who visited India from 1656 to 1668. **[1 Mark]**

• **Affiliation:** Served as personal physician to Mughal Prince Dara Shukoh and was associated with the intellectual court of Emperor Aurangzeb. **[1 Mark]**